

Magic or illusion?

Magic tricks date back to ancient times, and by the medieval era all kinds of magic were performed as street entertainment. Renaissance conjurers continued this tradition, bringing their illusions to marketplaces and fairs, as well as into the homes of aristocrats and royalty.

In this picture, an onlooker, who is fascinated by a magician's performance, fails to notice his purse being stolen. Frogs, apparently jumping from the onlooker's mouth, and an owl peeking from the conjurer's basket may symbolize heresy, devilry, clever bewitchment, or the loss of reason. On and around the conjurer's table are various tools of the trade, including those for the ancient "Cups and Balls" trick. Still popular today, this trick involves balls disappearing from under one cup and reappearing under another.

A Renaissance conjurer's repertoire included juggling, card tricks, and deceiving the eye with sleights of hand and illusions such as appearing to put a ring through a person's cheek. Two Renaissance texts contain some of the earliest published Western material on conjuring tricks. Luca Pacioli's *De viribus quantitatis* (*On the Powers of Numbers*, 1496–1508) included methods for performing tricks using numbers, illusions, and sleights of hand, while Reginald Scot's *Discoverie of Witchcraft* (1584) used the existence of such tricks to link magic with trickery rather than evil-doing and showed that it was irrational to fear witches (see pp.184–85).

“Commoners will consider [it] a miracle.”

LUCA PACIOLI, *DE VIRIBUS QUANTITATIS*, 1496–1508

